

lived to see Serena and Venus Williams do exactly that, but Black men have fallen short of Ashe's prediction.

With '9/11/01' etched on the court, Arthur Ashe Stadium spectators observed a moment of silence to commemorate the victims of 9/11 on its 25th anniversary. With several Black sports superstars in attendance — including Serena, Jalen Brunson and Cade Cunningham — Tiafoe hoped to pull an upset, just as he did against Nadal to reach the first of three semifinals here in 2022.

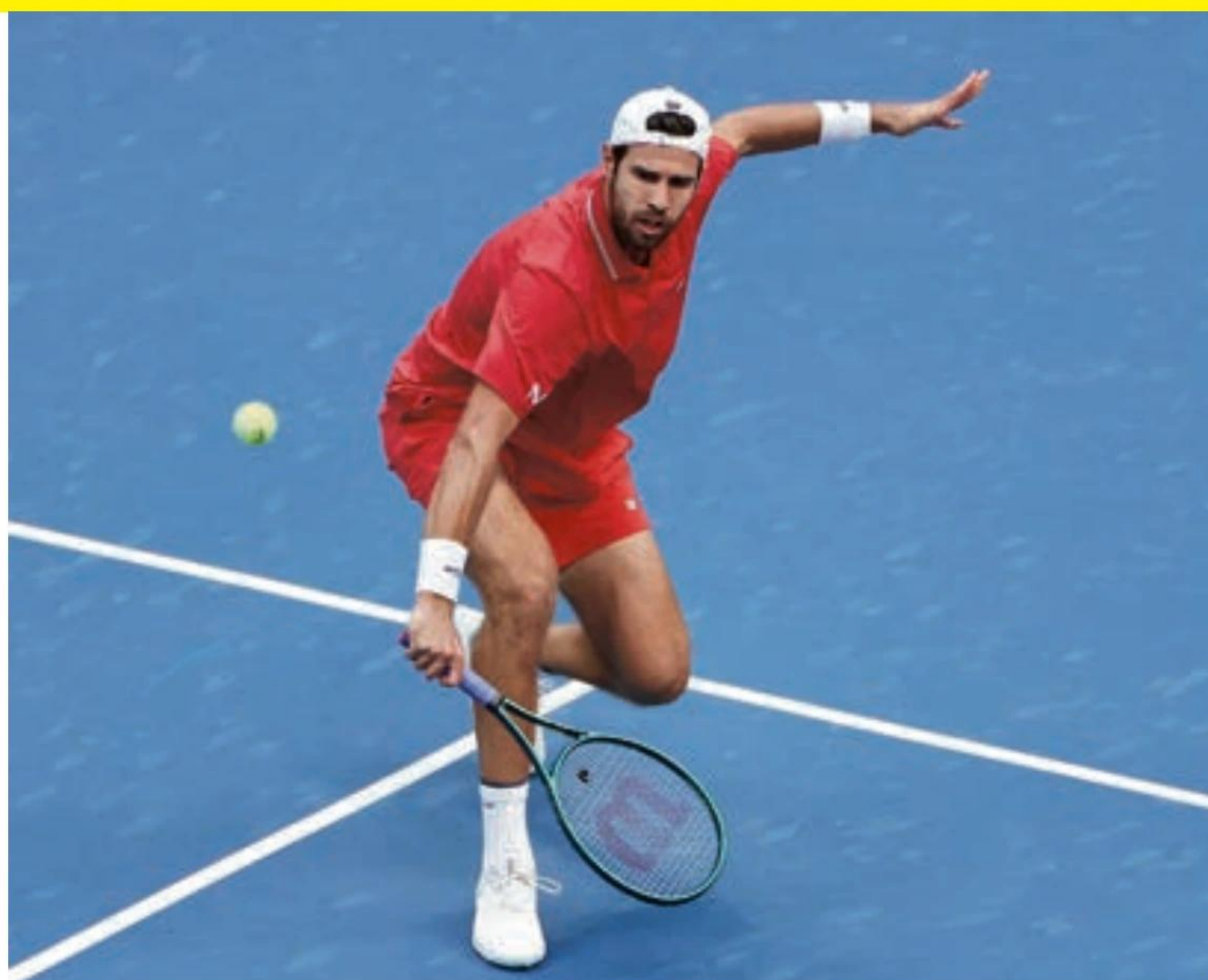
After overhitting and committing 14 unforced errors to give away the opening set, 6-4, Shelton quickly regrouped to break at love for 2-0, finishing with a forehand return-of-serve winner. Capitalising on Tiafoe's slow and inaccurate second serve was one key to Shelton's predictable 4-6, 6-3, 6-3, 7-5 triumph. The others were his improved backhand, superior first serve — 75 per cent, 20 aces and three double faults versus 57 per cent, three aces and two double faults for Tiafoe — and clutch play, converting five of 11 break points versus just two of seven for Tiafoe.

Tiafoe has said: "I'm not a big technique guy." Big mistake. Improving his volley and second serve technique is key to reaching his potential.

"Shelton is coming into his own, big-time, here," said John McEnroe. "He is in absolutely fantastic shape."

Would that be enough to upset Zverev, who won all five of their previous matches? No man had ever defeated the defending champion and the No. 1 seed before in the Open Era.

Furthermore, Zverev was undoubtedly playing the best tennis of his career, as his convincing 6-3, 7-6 (7), 7-6 (6) semifinal victory over Khachanov confirmed. He held serve 37 straight times until the 30-year-old Russian broke him in the second set. He hit forehands with more confidence and conviction than ever before. Once reluctant to come to the net, Sascha won 21 of 26 points there against Khachanov. It's absurd to describe him as merely



"fast for a big man" because he's one of the fastest players on the Tour. And he said he was never happier on a tennis court than during Wimbledon two months ago.

Shelton declared: "I've reached a level of belief I didn't have before," but he started his first Major final nervously. He double-faulted into the net on break point in the first game and again in the seventh game to give the first set away, 6-3.

Although Shelton got into the match in the second set and forced a tie-break, he still had won just three points off Zverev's seemingly impregnable serve. The German raced to a 5-0 lead in the breaker, sparked by unreturnable 139-mph and 147 (!) mph serves, and won it 7-2. Just as impressive, Sascha won 75 per cent of the points on long rallies (nine shots or more).

Big Ben raised the hopes of the partisan crowd when he broke serve to claim the third set 7-5, though Zverev choked, hitting an unforced forehand error and blowing an easy high forehand volley. Shelton smiled at his good fortune.

Zverev cleverly changed pace on break point to break serve in the opening game of the fourth set. It broke Shelton's brief momentum and quietened the sell-out crowd. The German was so focused that,

Fight to the end: Surprise package Karen Khachanov pushed Zverev hard in a gruelling three-hour, three-set battle. REUTERS

after breaking again for 5-2 and easily holding for 6-2 to clinch his second Grand Slam title, he walked back to get more balls, not realising the match was already over.

"Zverev played a phenomenal match," said McEnroe. "This is the best version of Zverev we've ever seen."

In his victory speech, Germany's first US Open champion since Boris Becker in 1989 thanked his father, Alexander Zverev Sr., and his older brother, Mischa, for their tireless coaching. But his most touching words were reserved for his mother, Irina, a former professional player.

When Sascha was diagnosed with type 1 diabetes at age four, doctors told his parents the condition would greatly limit his sports and life. His mom rejected that. He recalled her saying: "If he wants to be a tennis player, he'll be a tennis player. If he wants to do something else, he'll do something else. But this illness will not define us.' My mother is the most important and strongest person I know. It takes an unbelievably strong woman to do what she did."